

XIANGQI · VARIANT 3 OF 8

Jieqi

9×10
BOARD

2
PLAYERS

JIEQI

Jieqi (揭棋, “unveiling chess”) is a Xiangqi variant with hidden information. Also known as **Dark Chess**, **Cờ Úp** (Vietnamese), and by several other local names, it has seen rapid growth in popularity in China and Vietnam.

SETUP

The board, palace, river, and starting positions are identical to standard Xiangqi. However, at the start of the game **all pieces except the General are placed face-down** — covered so that their identity is not visible to either player. Covered pieces are placed randomly on the positions their piece type normally occupies:

- ♦ Each player’s 2 Advisors are randomly placed face-down on the Advisor squares.
- ♦ Each player’s 2 Elephants are randomly placed face-down on the Elephant squares.
- ♦ And so on for Horses, Chariots, Cannons, and Soldiers.

The **General begins face-up** in its normal starting square and is visible to both players at all times.

THE REVELATION MECHANIC

Covered pieces are informally called “fake pieces,” named after the starting position they occupy. For example, a covered piece on a Rook’s starting square is called a “fake Chariot.”

First move of a covered piece: When a covered piece makes its first move, it **must move as the piece whose starting position it occupies** — not as its true identity. A covered piece on a Chariot square must make a Chariot-legal move for its first move.

Revelation: After making its first move, the piece is turned face-up to reveal its true identity. From that point on, it moves as its actual piece type for the rest of the game.

REVEALED ADVISORS AND ELEPHANTS

Unlike in standard Xiangqi, revealed **Advisors** and **Elephants** are **not** restricted by the palace or the river. They can move to any valid square anywhere on the board. This is the only rule relaxation that applies to revealed pieces.

Generals remain confined to their palaces. **Soldiers** follow standard Xiangqi rules: forward only on their home side, sideways and forward after crossing the river.

CAPTURES

- ♦ A covered piece may be captured by an opponent’s piece in the normal way.
- ♦ When a covered piece is captured, its true identity is revealed **only to the capturing player**. The opponent does not learn the captured piece’s identity.
- ♦ Once a piece is revealed and on the board, both players can see its identity normally.

RULES

All standard Xiangqi rules apply to uncovered pieces: Flying General, palace restrictions for Generals, stalemate as a loss, perpetual check and chase rules.

WIN CONDITIONS

Checkmate the opponent's General. The General may never move into check. Stalemate is a loss for the player who cannot move.

ATTRIBUTION

Jieqi is a public domain variant of Xiangqi with historical roots. Rules documented from pychess.org/variants/jieqi.